

0-Advent of Cyber Prep Track 2025

Advent of Cyber Prep Track

Get ready for the Advent of Cyber 2025 with the "Advent of Cyber Prep Track", a series of warm-up tasks aimed to get beginners ready for this year's event.

Challenge 1 — Password Pandemonium

Password Pandemonium

As you log into your new TBFC workstation, an alert pops up:

“Weak passwords detected on 73 TBFC accounts!”

Even McSkidy’s password, `P@ssw0rd123` , has been flagged. Before gaining full access, you’ll need to prove your password prowess.

Strong passwords are one of the simplest yet most effective defences against cyber attacks.

Objective:

Create a password that passes all system checks and isn’t found in the leaked password list.

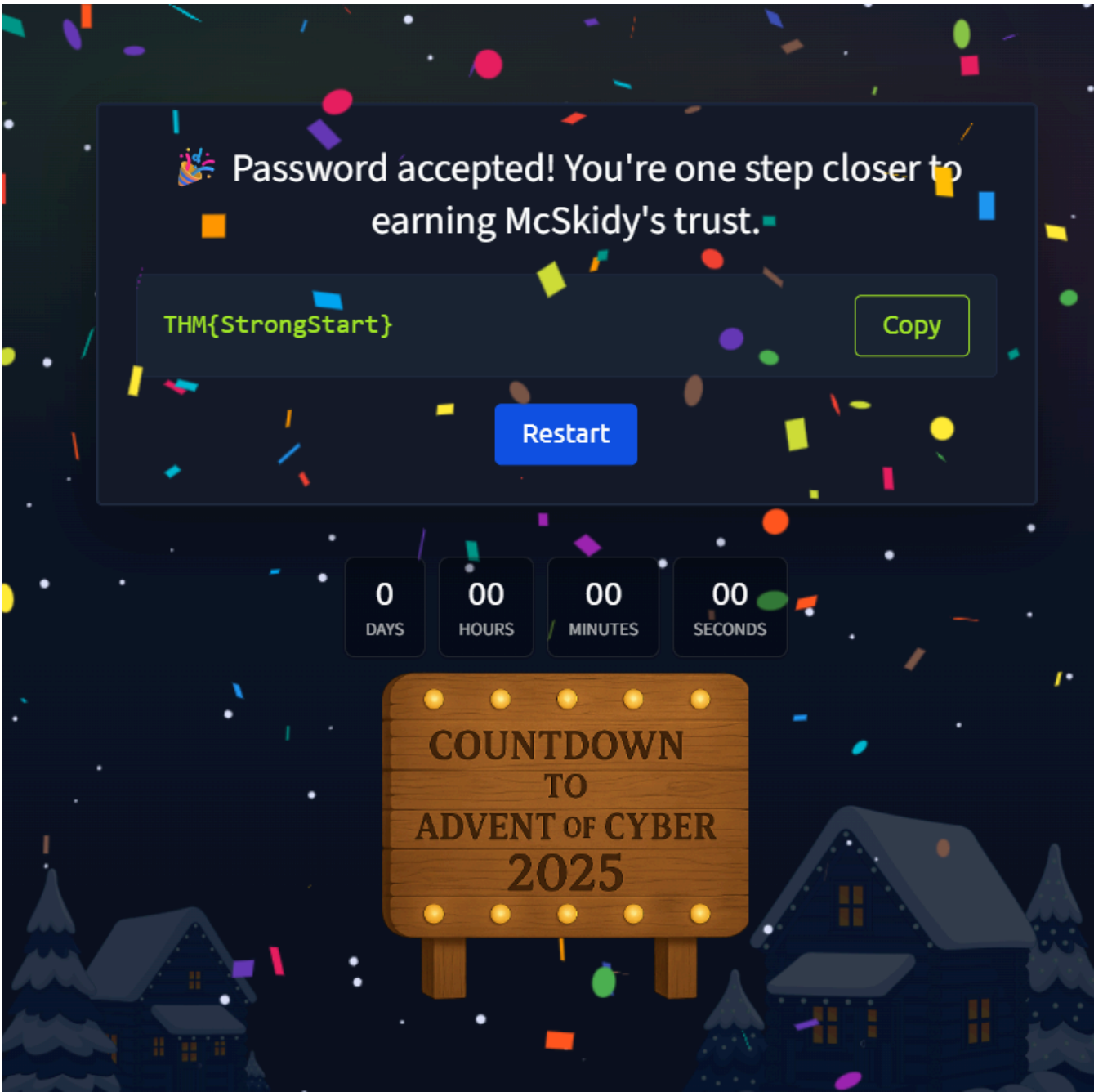
Steps:

- 1. Enter a password with at least 12 characters.
- 2. Include uppercase, lowercase, numbers, and symbols.
- 3. Ensure it isn’t in the breach database.

Answer the questions below

What's the flag?

THM{StrongStart}



Challenge 2 — The Suspicious Chocolate.exe

The Suspicious Chocolate.exe

A shiny USB labelled “SOCMAS Party Playlist” appears on your desk. Inside is a mysterious file called `chocolate.exe` . It looks festive, but who sent it?

In this challenge, you’ll scan the file using a simulated VirusTotal tool to decide whether it’s safe or malicious. Checking suspicious files is a crucial skill for every defender.

Objective:

Determine if `chocolate.exe` is safe or infected.

Steps:

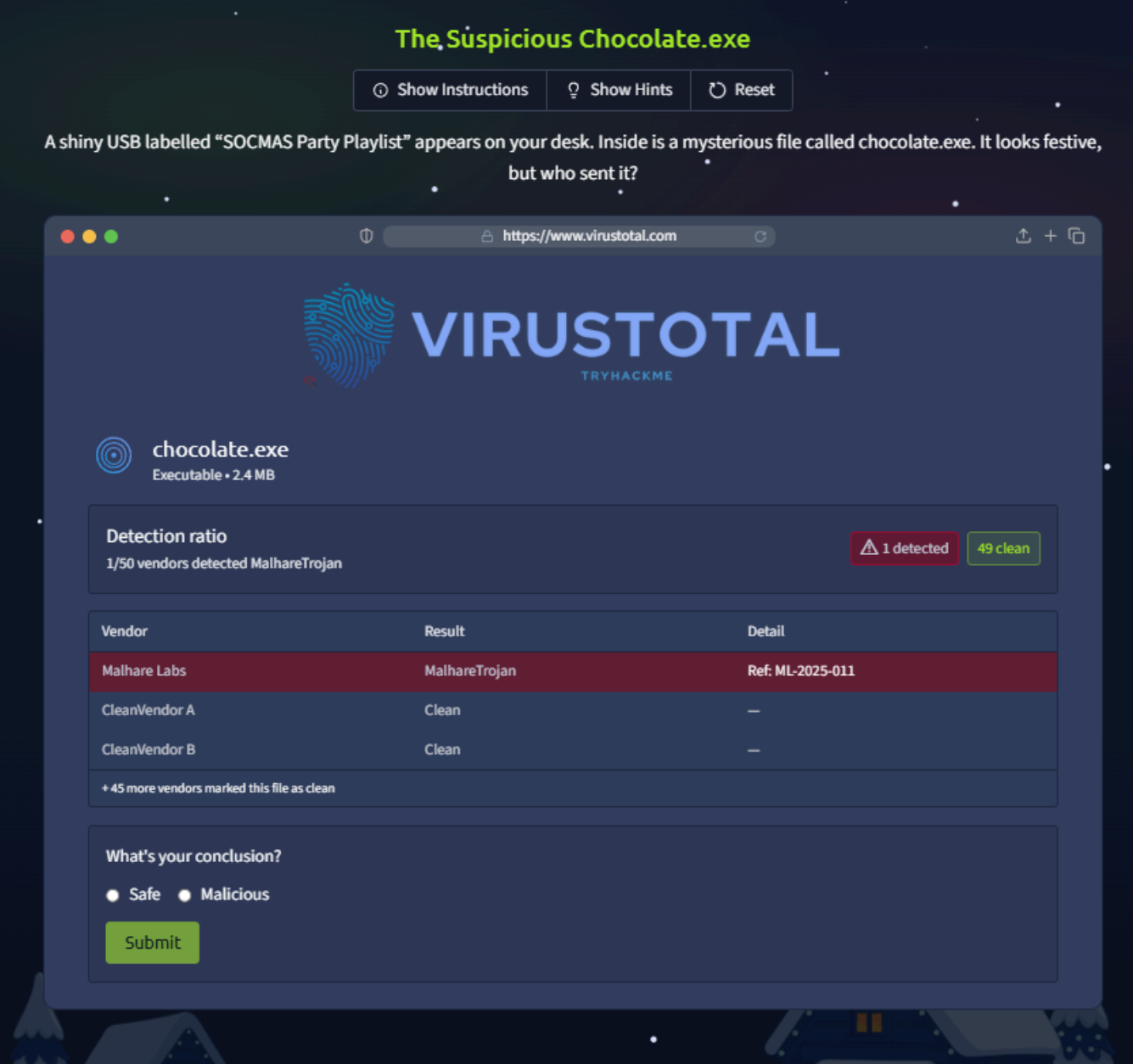
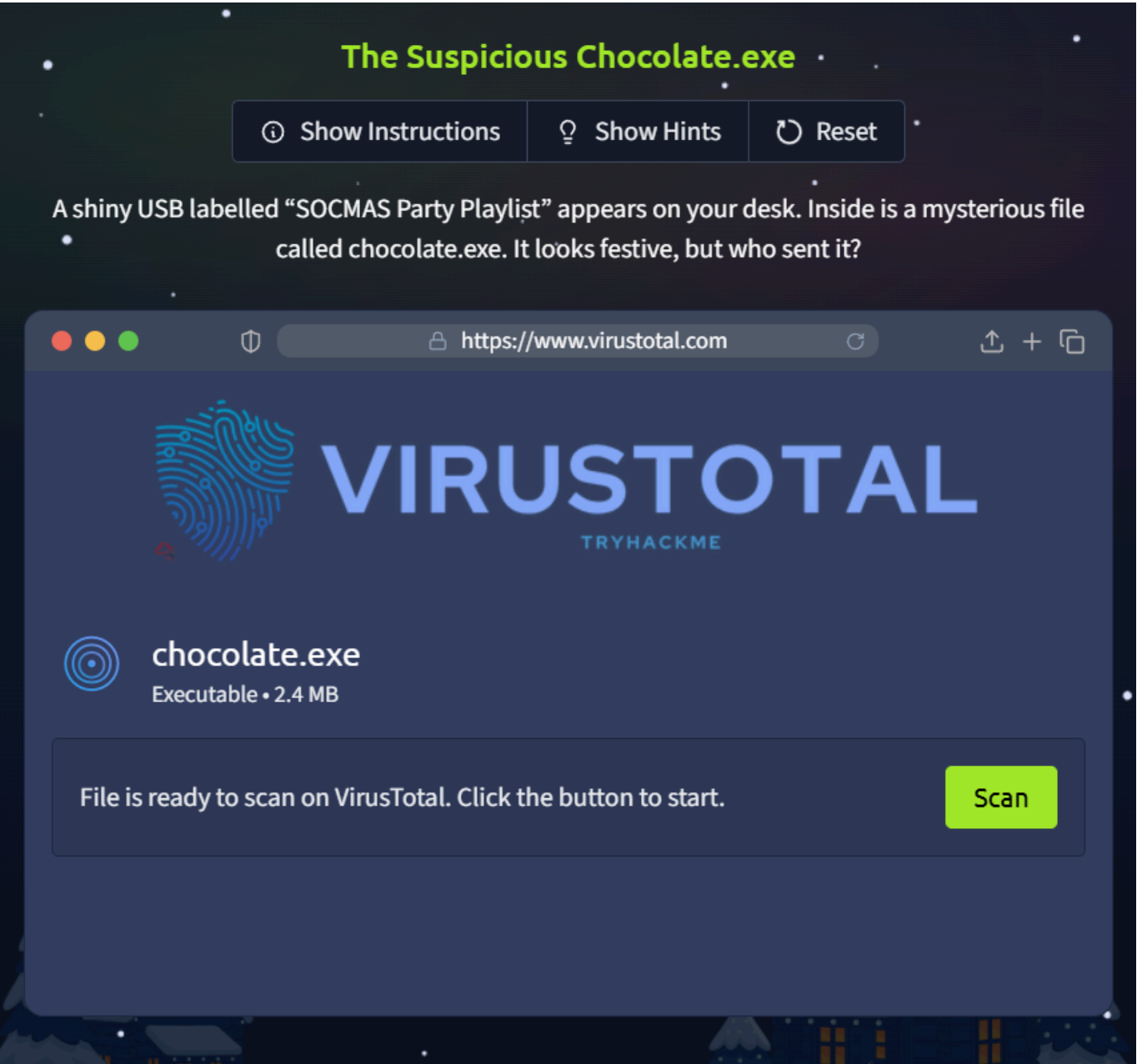
- 1. Click the “Scan” Button.

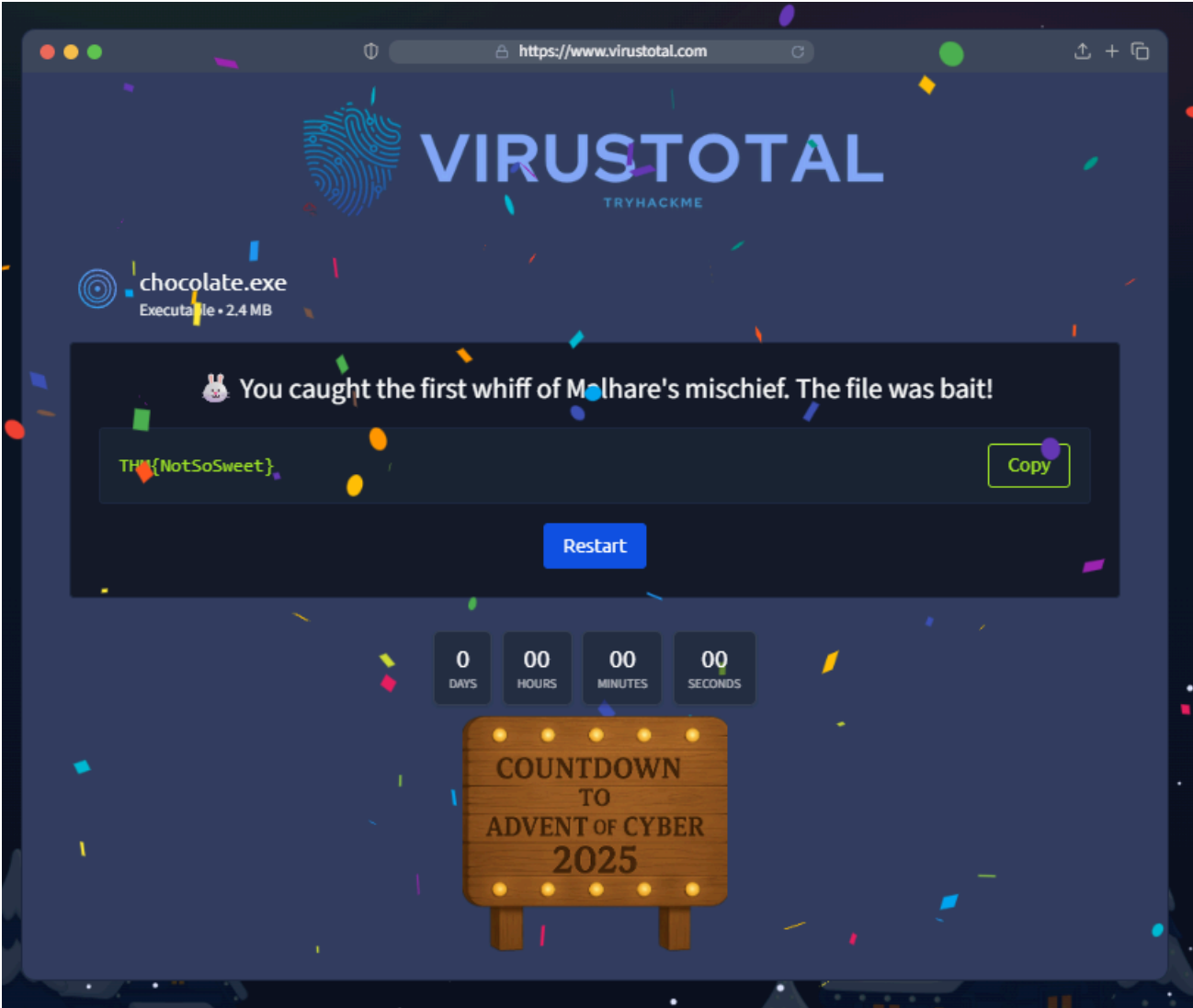
- 2. Review the scan report (49 clean results, 1 malicious).
- 3. Decide correctly whether the file is safe or dangerous.

Answer the questions below

What's the flag?

THM{NotSoSweet}





Challenge 3 — Welcome to the AttackBox!

Welcome to the AttackBox!

You step into TBFC’s **AttackBox**, a secure virtual environment built for training. The system hums quietly, waiting for your first command.

This is where defenders learn, break, and rebuild safely. Getting comfortable with the command line is your first step toward cyber mastery.

Objective:

Find and read the hidden welcome message inside your AttackBox.

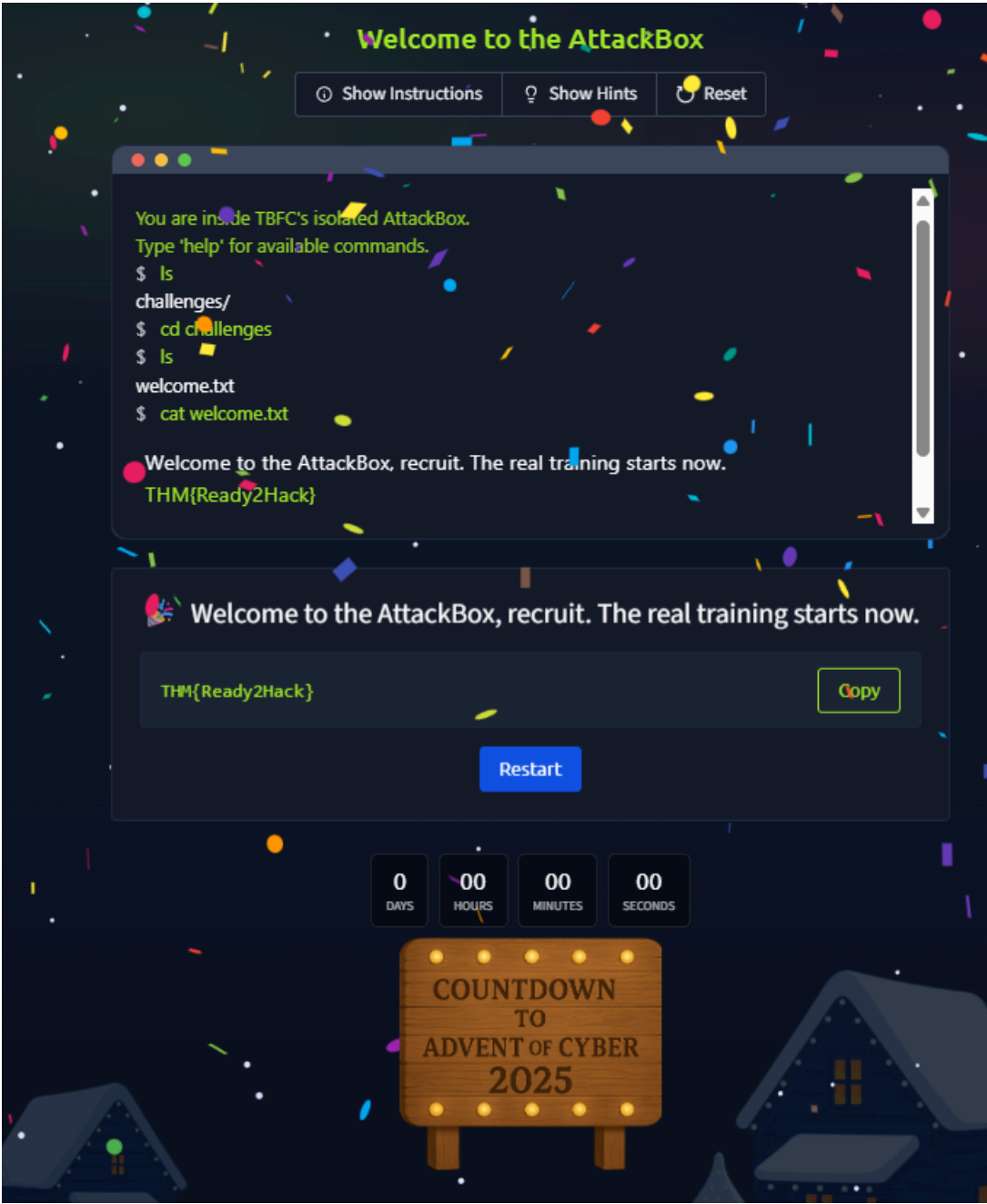
Steps:

- 1. Use `ls` to list files.
- 2. Use `cd challenges/` to change directories.
- 3. Use `cat welcome.txt` to read the text file.

Answer the questions below

What's the flag?

THM{Ready2Hack}



Challenge 4 — The CMD Conundrum

The CMD Conundrum

McSkidy’s workstation shows signs of tampering, suspicious files moved, logs wiped, and a strange folder named `mystery_data`.

It’s time to use the **Windows Command Prompt** to uncover what’s hidden. Learning these commands helps you investigate systems and find what the GUI can’t.

Objective:

Find the hidden flag file using Windows commands.

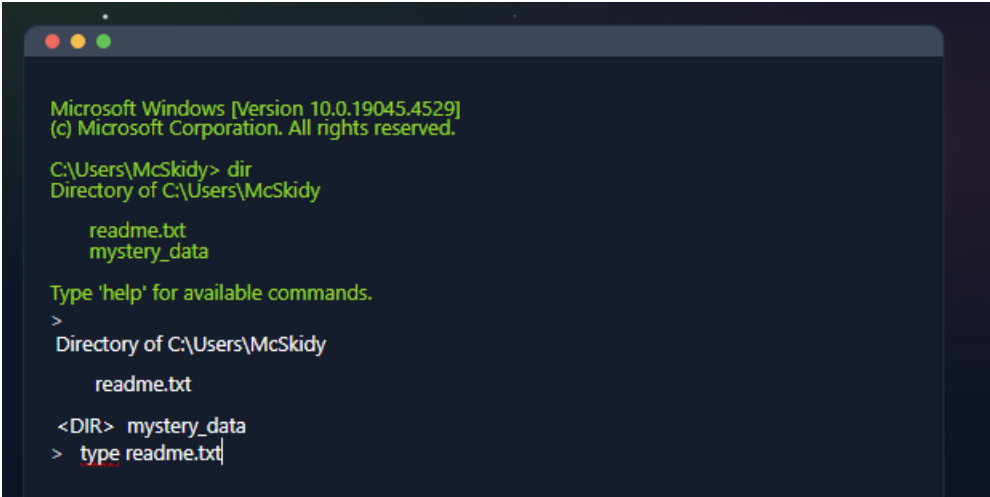
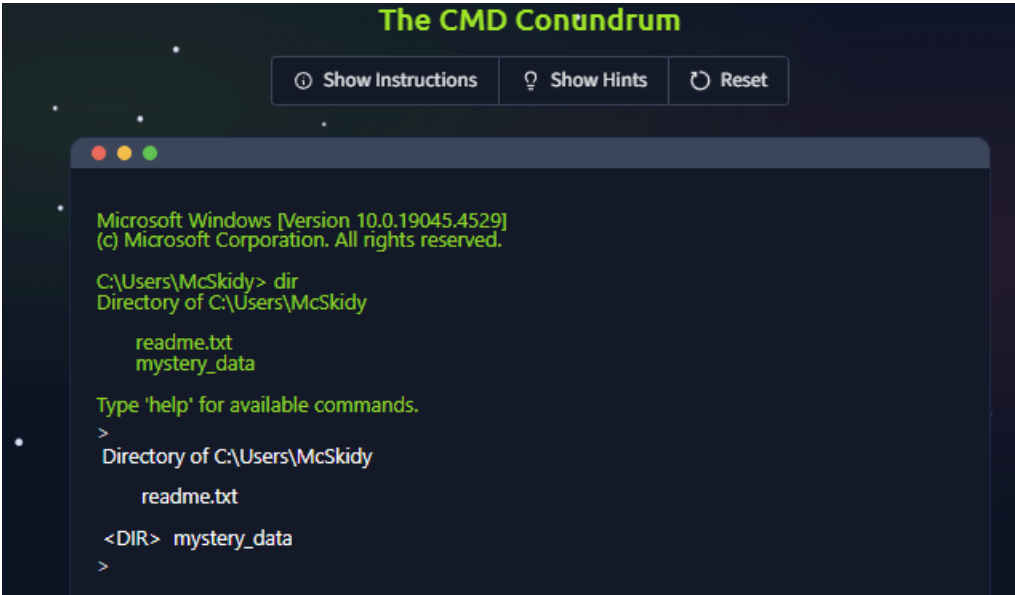
Steps:

1. Use `dir` to list visible files.
2. Try `dir /a` to reveal hidden ones.
3. Use `type hidden_flag.txt` to read the flag.

Answer the questions below

What's the flag?

THM{WhereIsMcSkidy}



```
Microsoft Windows [Version 10.0.19045.4529]
(c) Microsoft Corporation. All rights reserved.

C:\Users\McSkidy> dir
Directory of C:\Users\McSkidy

    readme.txt
    mystery_data

Type 'help' for available commands.
>
Directory of C:\Users\McSkidy

    readme.txt

<DIR>  mystery_data
>
System shows signs of tampering. Investigate the mystery_data directory.
>
```

```
Microsoft Windows [Version 10.0.19045.4529]
(c) Microsoft Corporation. All rights reserved.

C:\Users\McSkidy> dir
Directory of C:\Users\McSkidy

    readme.txt
    mystery_data

Type 'help' for available commands.
>
Directory of C:\Users\McSkidy

    readme.txt

<DIR>  mystery_data
>
System shows signs of tampering. Investigate the mystery_data directory.
> cd mystery_data|
```

```
Microsoft Windows [Version 10.0.19045.4529]
(c) Microsoft Corporation. All rights reserved.

C:\Users\McSkidy> dir
Directory of C:\Users\McSkidy

    readme.txt
    mystery_data

Type 'help' for available commands.
>
Directory of C:\Users\McSkidy

    readme.txt

<DIR>  mystery_data
>
System shows signs of tampering. Investigate the mystery_data directory.
>
C:\Users\McSkidy> cd mystery_data
> |
```

```
Microsoft Windows [Version 10.0.19045.4529]
(c) Microsoft Corporation. All rights reserved.

C:\Users\McSkidy> dir
Directory of C:\Users\McSkidy

    readme.txt
    mystery_data

Type 'help' for available commands.
>
Directory of C:\Users\McSkidy

    readme.txt

<DIR>  mystery_data
>
System shows signs of tampering. Investigate the mystery_data directory.
>
C:\Users\McSkidy> cd mystery_data
> dir /a|
```



```
Microsoft Windows [Version 10.0.19045.4529]
(c) Microsoft Corporation. All rights reserved.

C:\Users\McSkidy> dir
Directory of C:\Users\McSkidy

    readme.txt
    mystery_data

Type 'help' for available commands.
>
Directory of C:\Users\McSkidy

    readme.txt

<DIR>  mystery_data
>
System shows signs of tampering. Investigate the mystery_data directory.
>
C:\Users\McSkidy> cd mystery_data
>
Directory of C:\Users\McSkidy\mystery_data

    notes.txt

    hidden_flag.txt (hidden)
>
```

```
Microsoft Windows [Version 10.0.19045.4529]
(c) Microsoft Corporation. All rights reserved.

C:\Users\McSkidy> dir
Directory of C:\Users\McSkidy

    readme.txt
    mystery_data

Type 'help' for available commands.
>
Directory of C:\Users\McSkidy

    readme.txt

<DIR>  mystery_data
>
System shows signs of tampering. Investigate the mystery_data directory.
>
C:\Users\McSkidy> cd mystery_data
>
Directory of C:\Users\McSkidy\mystery_data

    notes.txt

    hidden_flag.txt (hidden)
> type hidden_flag.txt
```

The CMD Conundrum

Show InstructionsShow HintsReset

```
Microsoft Windows [Version 10.0.19045.4529]
(c) Microsoft Corporation. All rights reserved.

C:\Users\McSkidy> dir
Directory of C:\Users\McSkidy

    readme.txt
    mystery_data

Type 'help' for available commands.
>
Directory of C:\Users\McSkidy

    readme.txt

<DIR>  mystery_data
>
System shows signs of tampering. Investigate the mystery_data directory.
>
C:\Users\McSkidy> cd mystery_data
>
Directory of C:\Users\McSkidy\mystery_data

    notes.txt

    hidden_flag.txt (hidden)

>
Accessing: hidden_flag.txt
THM{WhereIsMcSkidy}
>
```

 Good work! Keep going.

THM{WhereIsMcSkidy}

Copy

Restart

Linux Lore

TBFC’s delivery drones are glitching, dropping eggs instead of presents! McSkidy’s last login came from a Linux server, and something in his account might explain why.

Linux powers most servers worldwide, and knowing how to search within it is a must for any defender.

Objective:

Locate McSkidy’s hidden message in his Linux home directory.

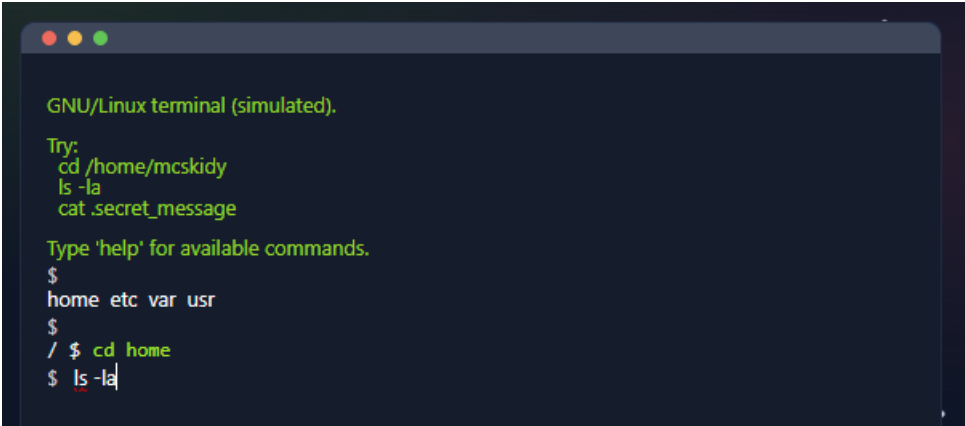
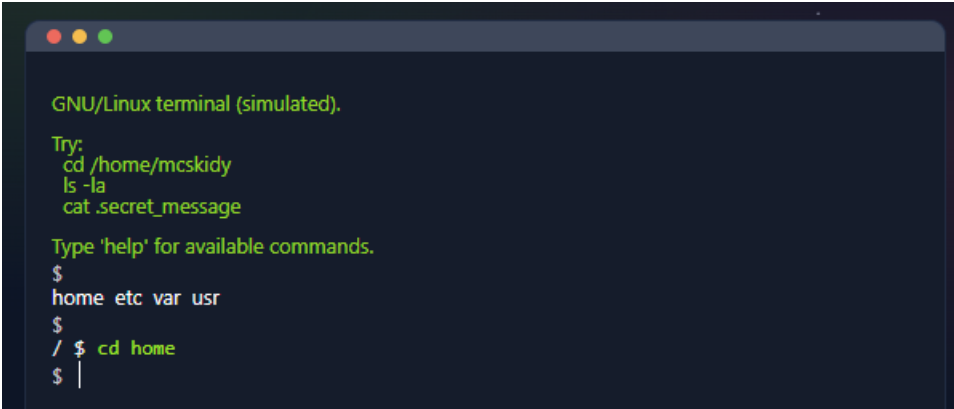
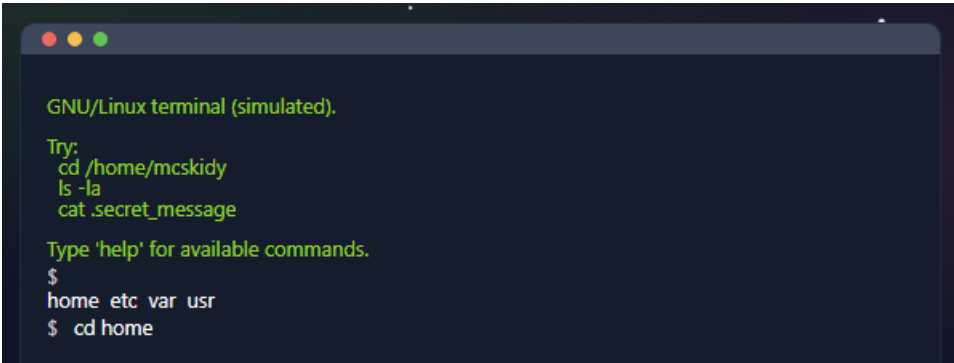
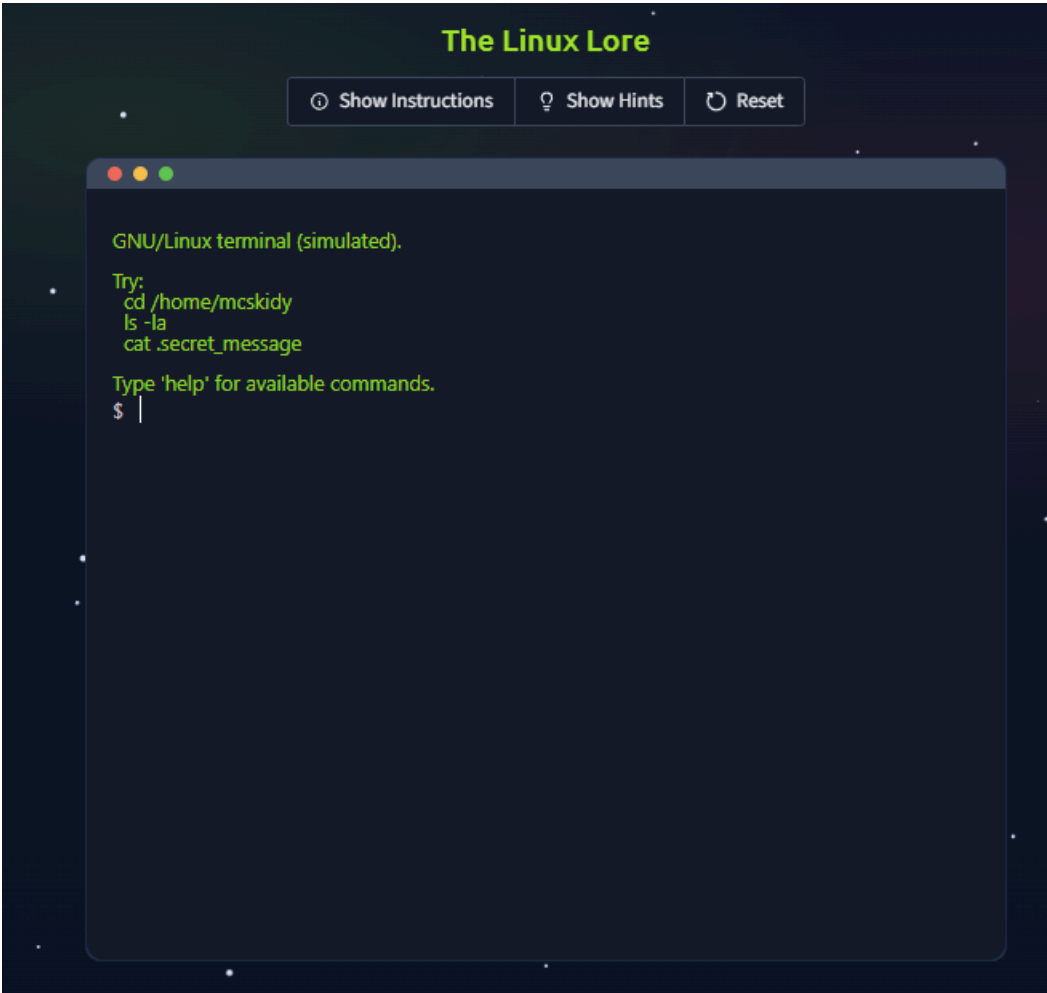
Steps:

- 1. Use `cd /home/mcskidy/` to enter his folder.
- 2. Run `ls -la` to show all files.
- 3. Use `cat .secret_message` to reveal the flag.

Answer the questions below

What's the flag?

THM{TrustNoBunny}




```
GNU/Linux terminal (simulated).

Try:
cd /home/mcskidy
ls -la
cat .secret_message

Type 'help' for available commands.
$
home etc var usr
$
/ $ cd home
$
drwxr-xr-x root root 1 Jan 1 00:00 mcskidy
$ |
```

```
GNU/Linux terminal (simulated).

Try:
cd /home/mcskidy
ls -la
cat .secret_message

Type 'help' for available commands.
$
home etc var usr
$
/ $ cd home
$
drwxr-xr-x root root 1 Jan 1 00:00 mcskidy
$
/home $ cd mcskidy
$
```

```
GNU/Linux terminal (simulated).

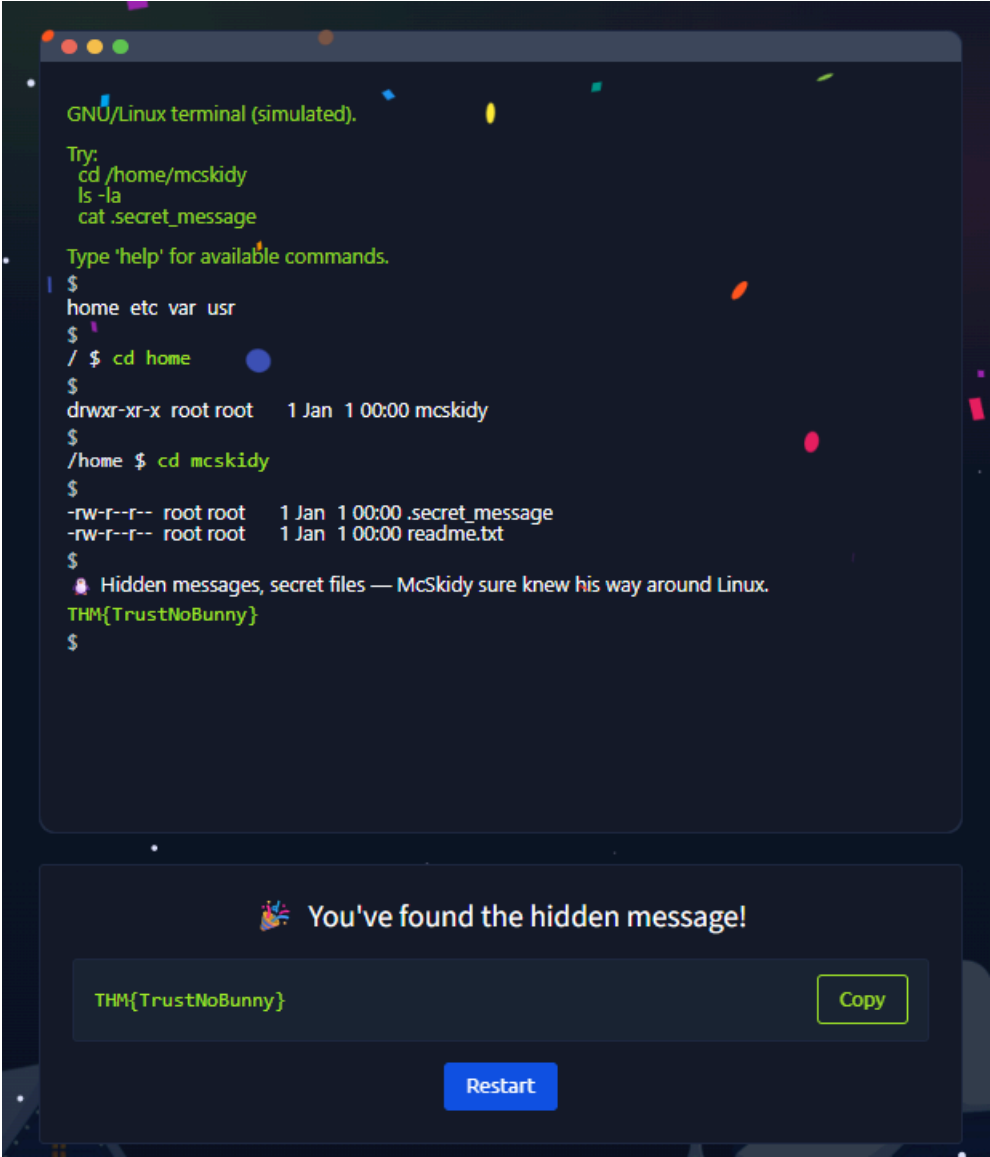
Try:
cd /home/mcskidy
ls -la
cat .secret_message

Type 'help' for available commands.
$
home etc var usr
$
/ $ cd home
$
drwxr-xr-x root root 1 Jan 1 00:00 mcskidy
$
/home $ cd mcskidy
$ ls -la|
```

```
GNU/Linux terminal (simulated).

Try:
cd /home/mcskidy
ls -la
cat .secret_message

Type 'help' for available commands.
$
home etc var usr
$
/ $ cd home
$
drwxr-xr-x root root 1 Jan 1 00:00 mcskidy
$
/home $ cd mcskidy
$
-rw-r--r-- root root 1 Jan 1 00:00 .secret_message
-rw-r--r-- root root 1 Jan 1 00:00 readme.txt
$
```



Challenge 6 — The Leak in the List

The Leak in the List

Rumours swirl that TBFC’s data has been leaked. Emails are bouncing, and the staff are panicking. McSkidy suspects his account might have been part of a breach.

Defenders often use tools like **Have I Been Pwned** to check for compromised accounts. Early detection can stop an attack from spreading.

Objective:

Check if McSkidy’s email has appeared in a breach.

Steps:

1. Enter `mcskidy@tbfc.com` into the breach checker.
2. Review results for each domain.
3. Identify the one marked “Compromised.”

Answer the questions below

What's the flag?

THM{LeakedAndFound}

The Leak in the List

Show Instructions

Show Hints

Reset

Have I Been Pwned? (Simulated)

Check if an email address appears in known breaches. Inspired by [Have I Been Pwned](#).

Enter email address

Check

pwned websites

919

pwned accounts

17,281,955,082

Have I Been Pwned? (Simulated)

Check if an email address appears in known breaches. Inspired by [Have I Been Pwned](#).

mcskidy@tbfc.com

Check

pwned websites

919

pwned accounts

17,281,955,082

Have I Been Pwned? (Simulated)

Check if an email address appears in known breaches. Inspired by [Have I Been Pwned](#).

mcskidy@tbfc.com

Check

Oh no — pwned!

This email address has been found in simulated breach records.

Domain	Status	Date
giftlist.tbfc	Safe	2024-11-02
hopsec.io	Compromised	2025-01-16
warehouse.tbfc	Safe	2023-08-09

pwned websites

919

pwned accounts

17,281,955,082

Have I Been Pwned? (Simulated)

Check if an email address appears in known breaches. Inspired by [Have I Been Pwned](#).

mcskidy@tbfc.com

Check

Oh no — pwned!

This email address has been found in simulated breach records.

Domain	Status	Date
giftlist.tbfc	Safe	2024-11-02
hopsec.io	Compromised	2025-01-16
warehouse.tbfc	Safe	2023-08-09

💡 HopSec strikes again. They've been planning something big.

THM{LeakedAndFound}

Copy

Restart

WiFi Woes in Wareville

The TBFC drones are looping endlessly over Wareville Square. Someone logged into the company router using default credentials!

Securing WiFi is critical. Default passwords are like leaving the front gate wide open.

Objective:

Log into the router and secure it with a strong new password.

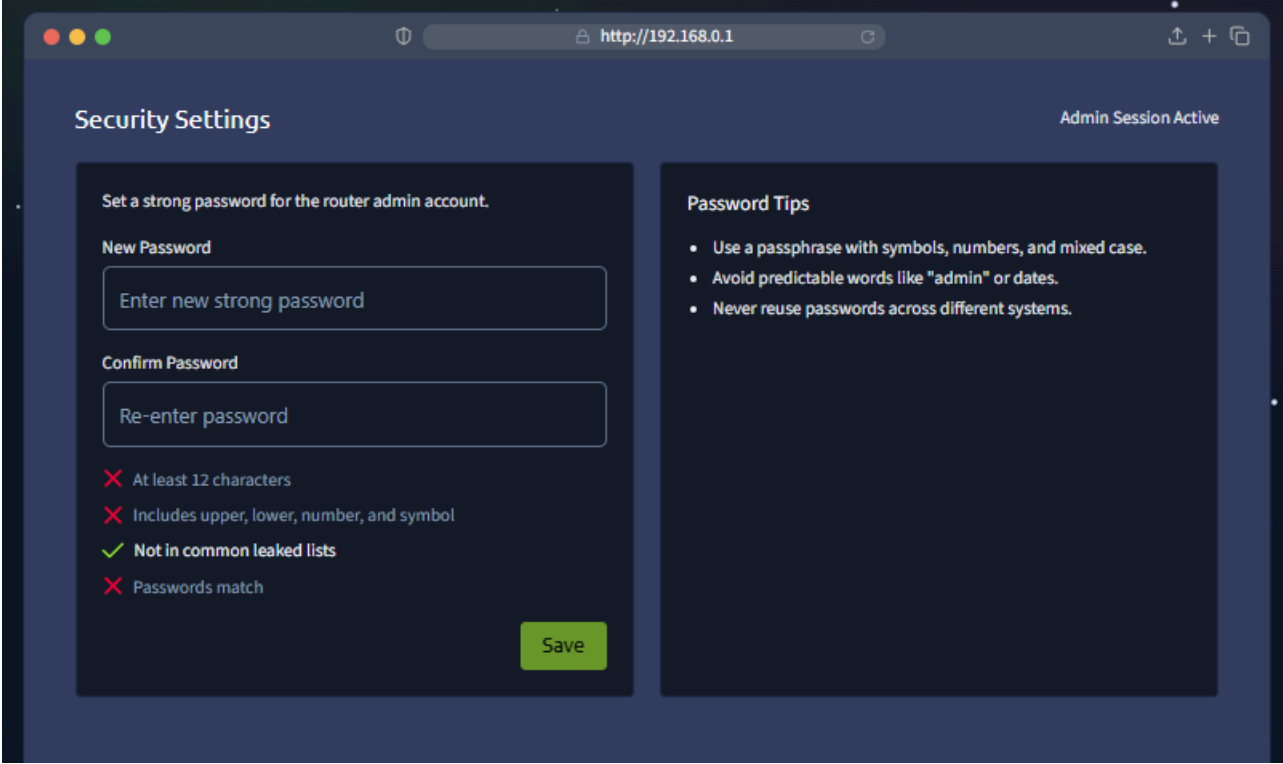
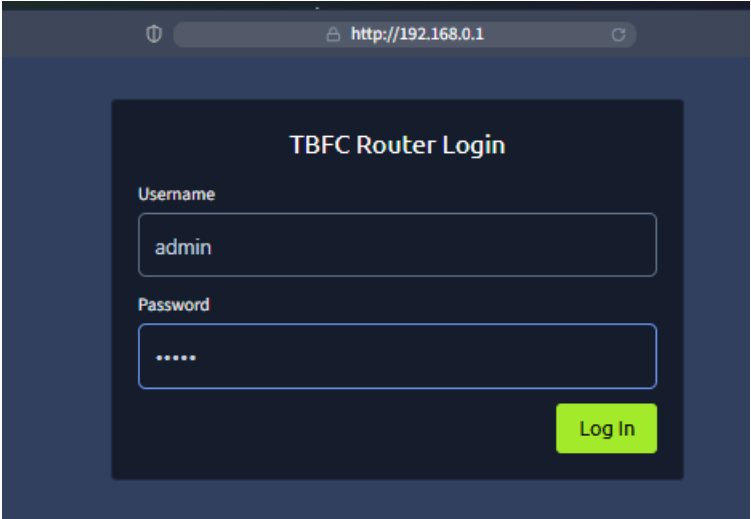
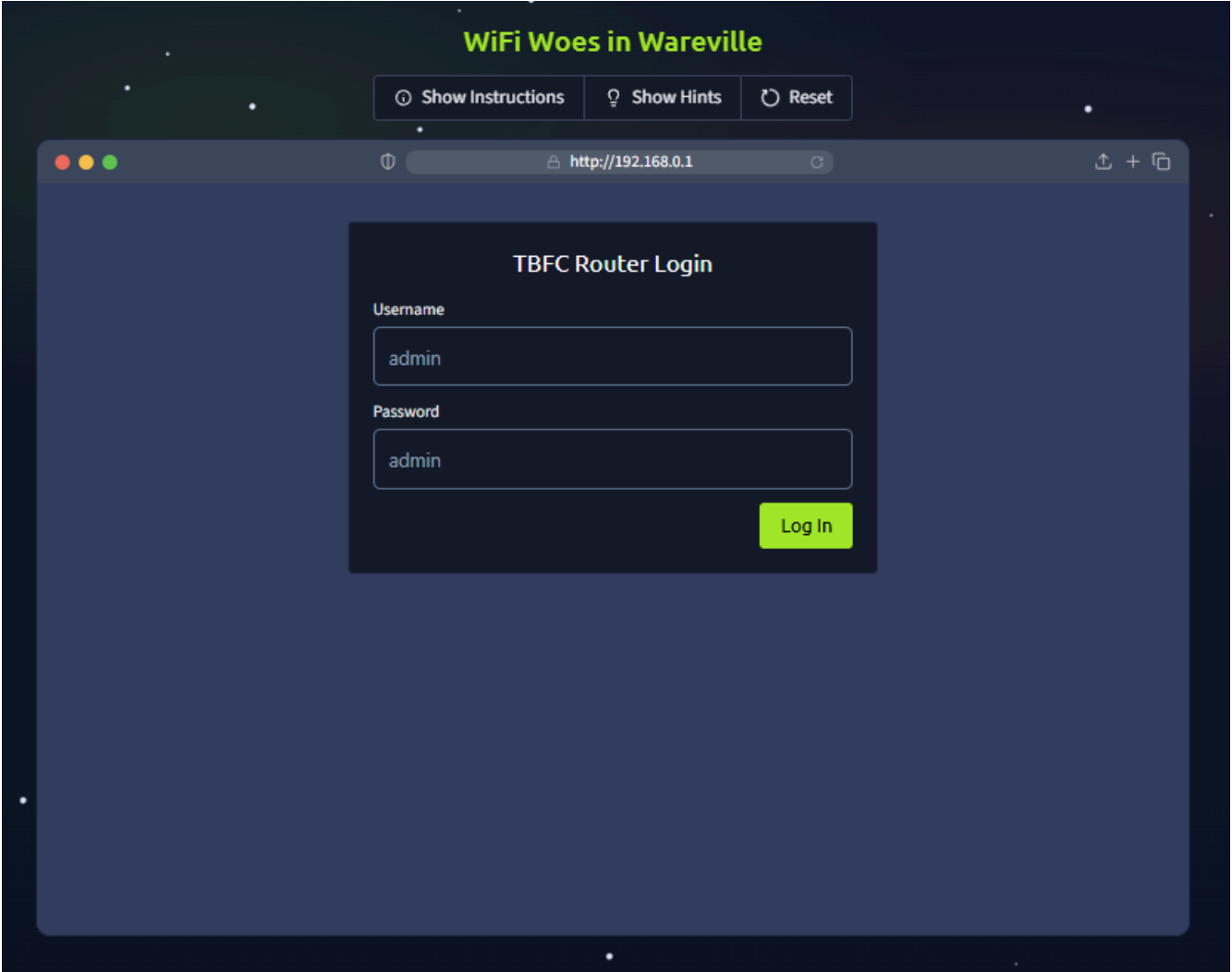
Steps:

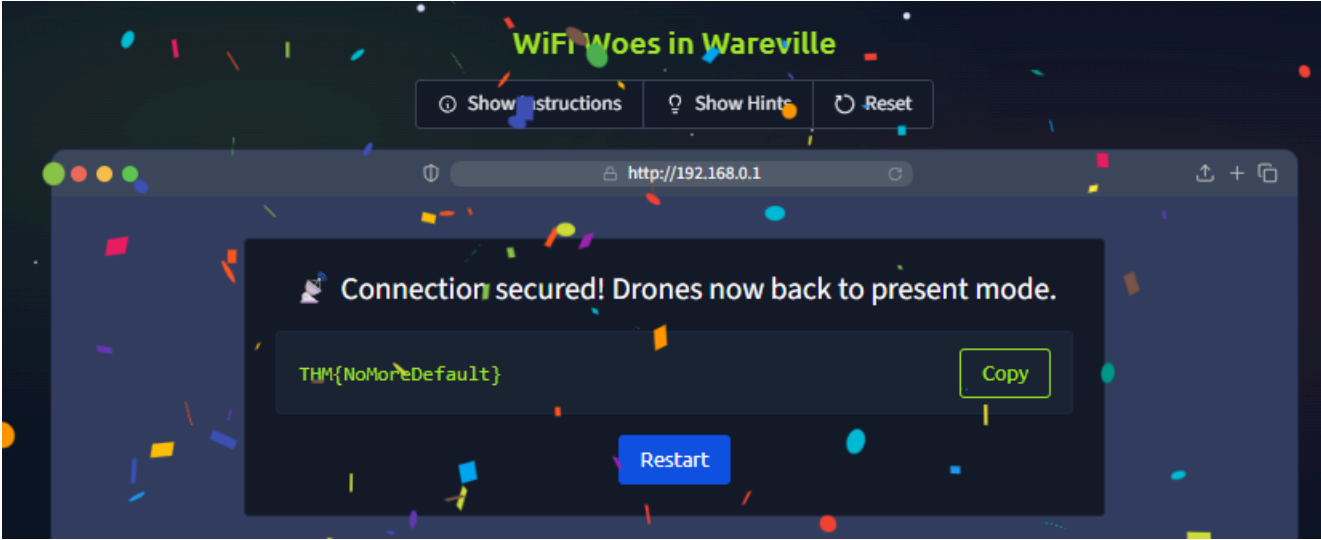
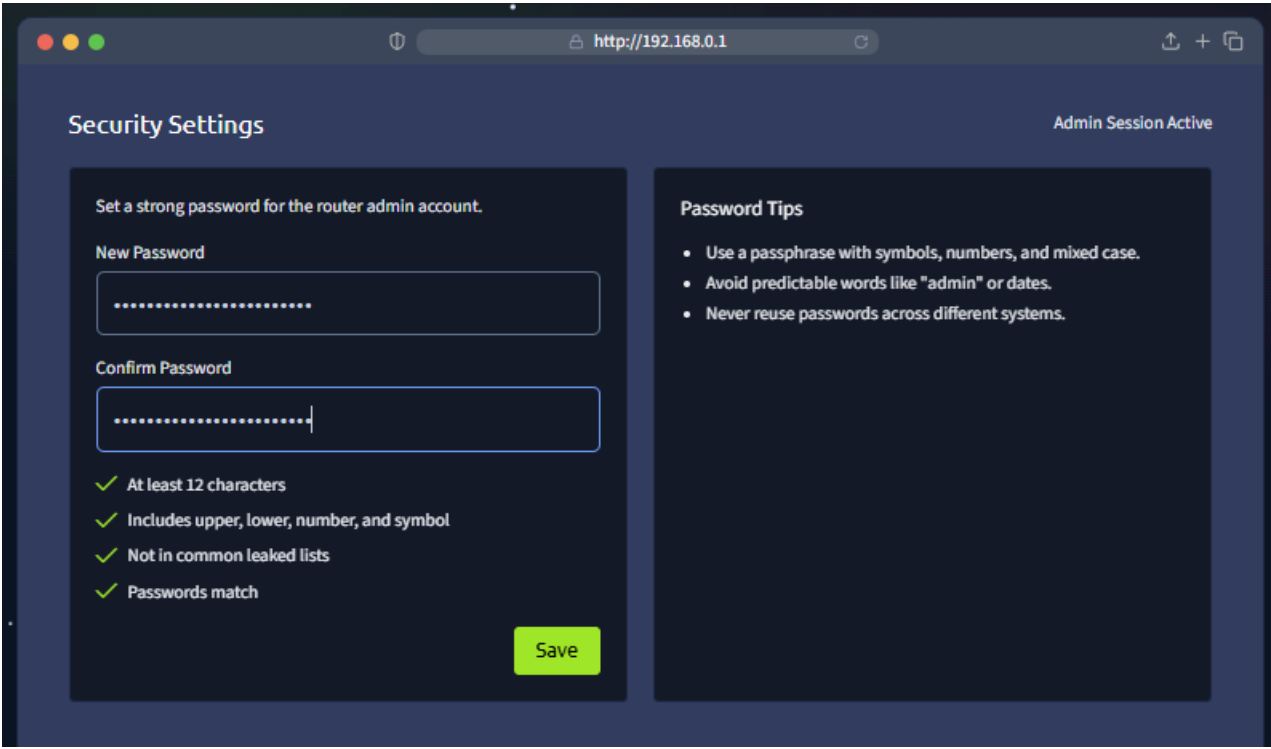
1. Log in with username `admin` and password `admin`.
2. Go to “Security Settings.”
3. Set a new strong password that passes validation.

Answer the questions below

What's the flag?

THM{NoMoreDefault}





Challenge 8 — The App Trap

The App Trap

McSkidy’s social account has gone rogue, posting strange messages about “EASTMAS.” A suspicious third party app may be behind it.

Learning to review and manage app permissions helps stop data leaks before they start.

Objective:

Find and remove the malicious connected app.

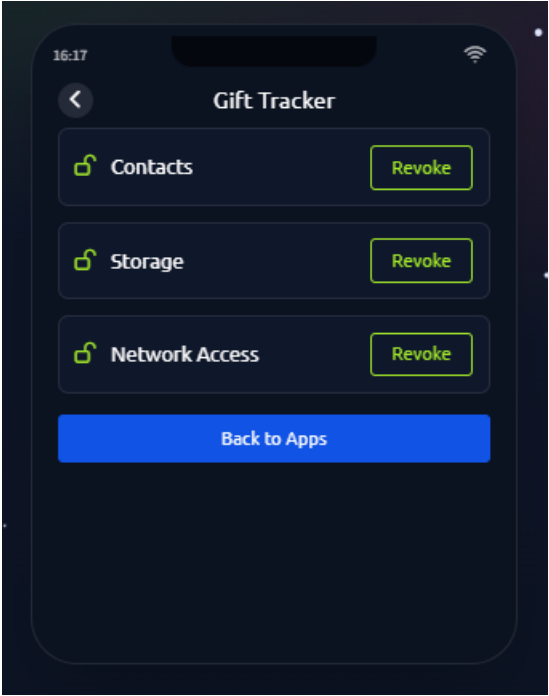
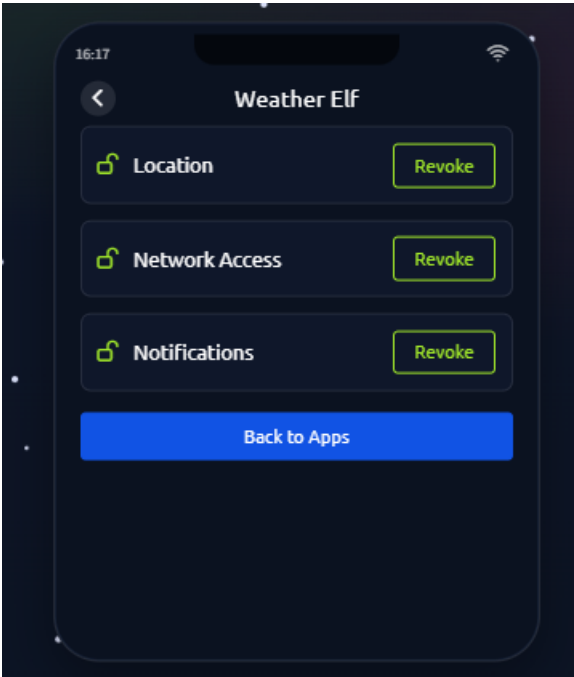
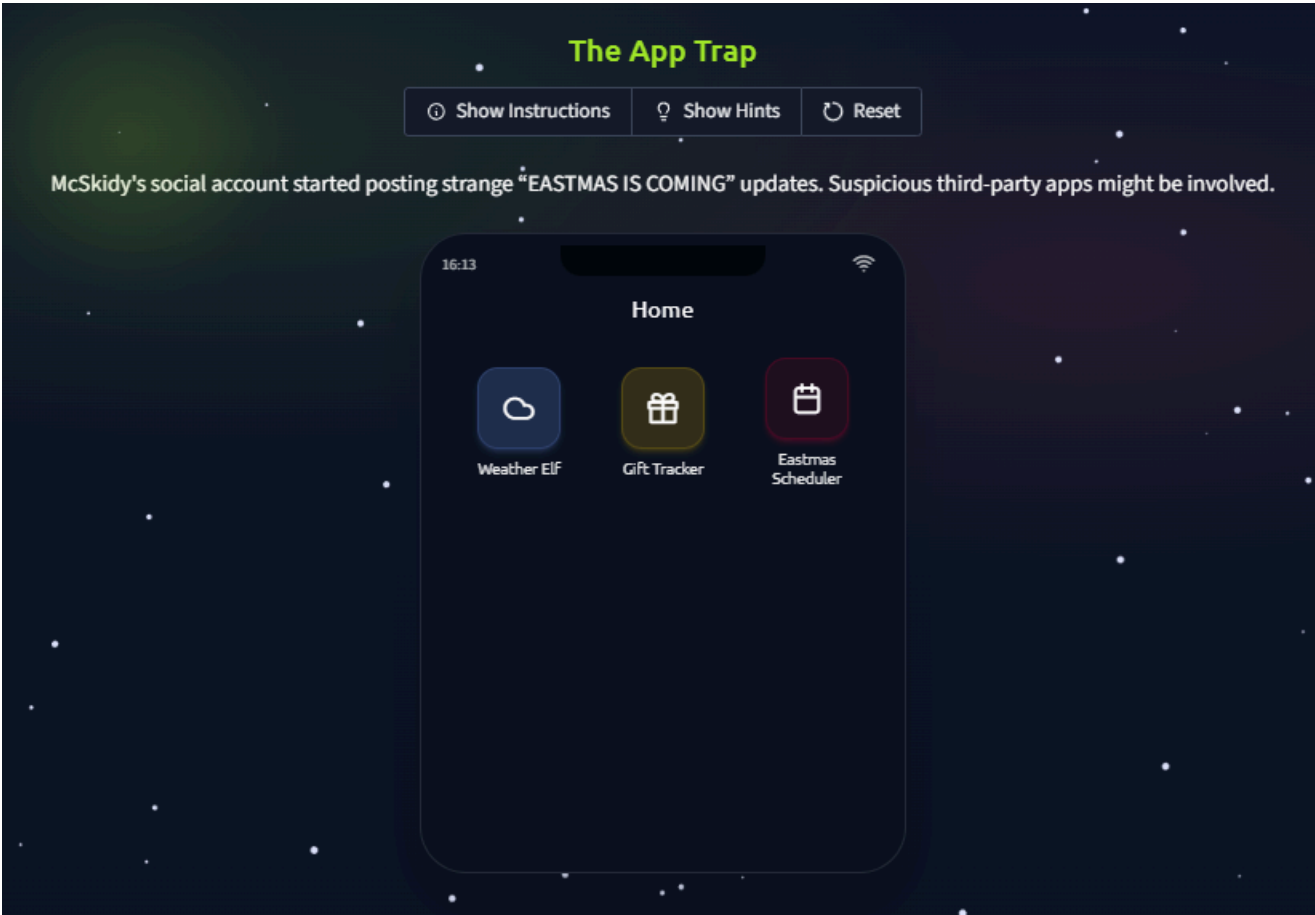
Steps:

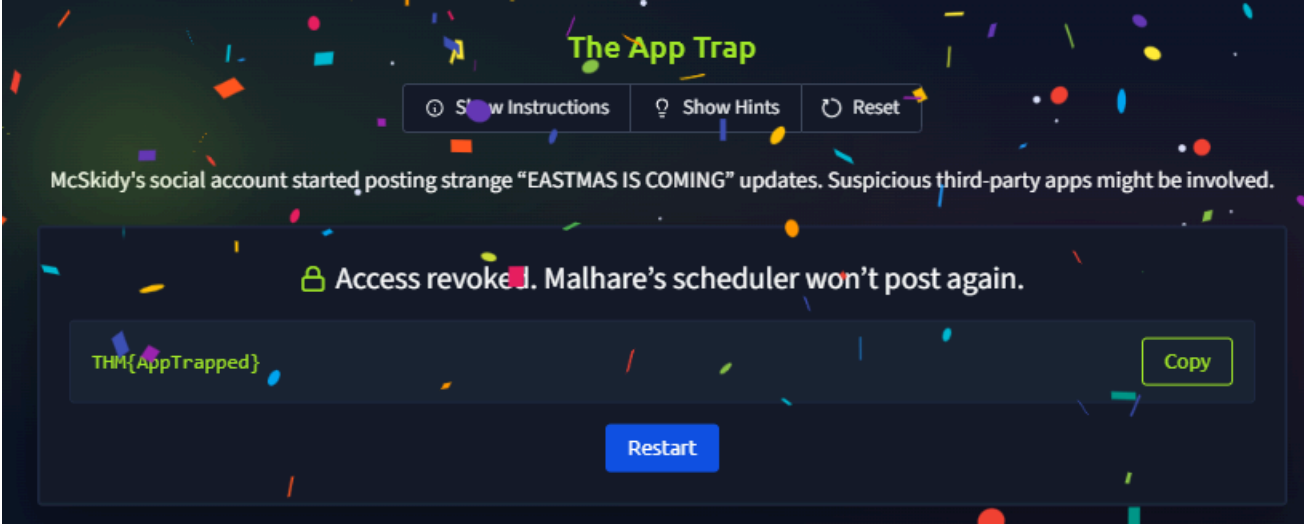
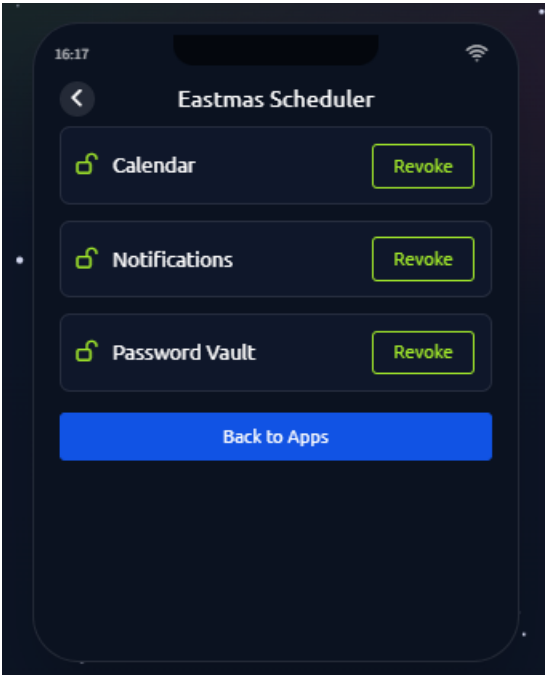
- 1. Review the list of connected apps.
- 2. Look for one with unusual permissions (like “password vault” access).
- 3. Click “Revoke Access.”

Answer the questions below

What's the flag?

THM{AppTrapped}





Challenge 9 — The Chatbot Confession

The Chatbot Confession

TBFC’s AI assistant, **FestiveBot**, was meant to help write cheerful emails, but it’s been spilling secrets. Some messages reveal internal URLs and even passwords.

AI tools can be powerful, but defenders must know how to prevent them from oversharing.

Objective:

Identify which chatbot messages contain sensitive information.

Steps:

1. Read each line of the conversation.
2. Select the ones containing private data.
3. Submit your findings.

Answer the questions below

What's the flag?

THM{DontFeedTheBot}

The Chatbot Confession

- Show Instructions
- Show Hints
- Reset

TBFC's AI assistant, FestiveBot, was meant to help write cheerful emails, but it's been spilling secrets. Some messages reveal internal URLs and even passwords.

Chat with FestiveBot

YOU

FestiveBot, can you draft a cheerful end-of-year message for the TBFC staff?

FESTIVEBOT

Absolutely! Here's a friendly message celebrating achievements and wishing a happy holiday season.

FESTIVEBOT

Reminder: staging admin lives at <https://internal.tbfc.local/admin> for content approvals.

FESTIVEBOT

If you need the gift budget spreadsheet, check the shared drive link I mentioned earlier.

FESTIVEBOT

Email credentials as requested: user festive.ops and password SnowGlobe#2025.

FESTIVEBOT

We should avoid sharing personal details; always keep things general and upbeat!

FESTIVEBOT

Service token: sk-live-1a2b3c4d5e6f7g8h for the mail API. Use it sparingly.

FESTIVEBOT

Here's a sign-off: Wishing you warmth, joy, and a secure new year!

TBFC's AI assistant, FestiveBot, was meant to help write cheerful emails, but it's been spilling secrets. Some messages reveal internal URLs and even passwords.

Chat with FestiveBot

YOU

FestiveBot, can you draft a cheerful end-of-year message for the TBFC staff?

FESTIVEBOT

Absolutely! Here's a friendly message celebrating achievements and wishing a happy holiday season.

Selected

FESTIVEBOT

Reminder: staging admin lives at <https://internal.tbfc.local/admin> for content approvals.

FESTIVEBOT

If you need the gift budget spreadsheet, check the shared drive link I mentioned earlier.

Selected

FESTIVEBOT

Email credentials as requested: user festive.ops and password SnowGlobe#2025.

FESTIVEBOT

We should avoid sharing personal details; always keep things general and upbeat!

Selected

FESTIVEBOT

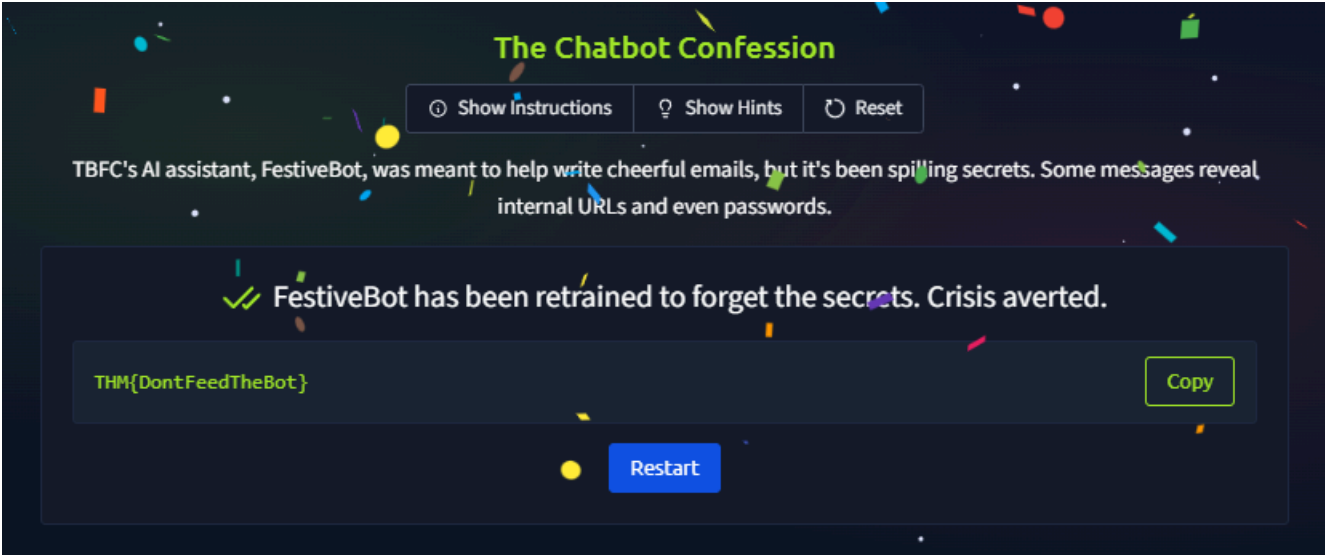
Service token: sk-live-1a2b3c4d5e6f7g8h for the mail API. Use it sparingly.

FESTIVEBOT

Here's a sign-off: Wishing you warmth, joy, and a secure new year!

Submit

Reset



Challenge 10 — The Bunny’s Browser Trail

The Bunny’s Browser Trail

SOCMAS web servers are showing heavy traffic, but one log entry stands out:

“User Agent: BunnyOS/1.0 (HopSecBot)”

Someone or something has infiltrated the system.
User Agent strings help defenders spot automated or suspicious visitors in network logs.

Objective:

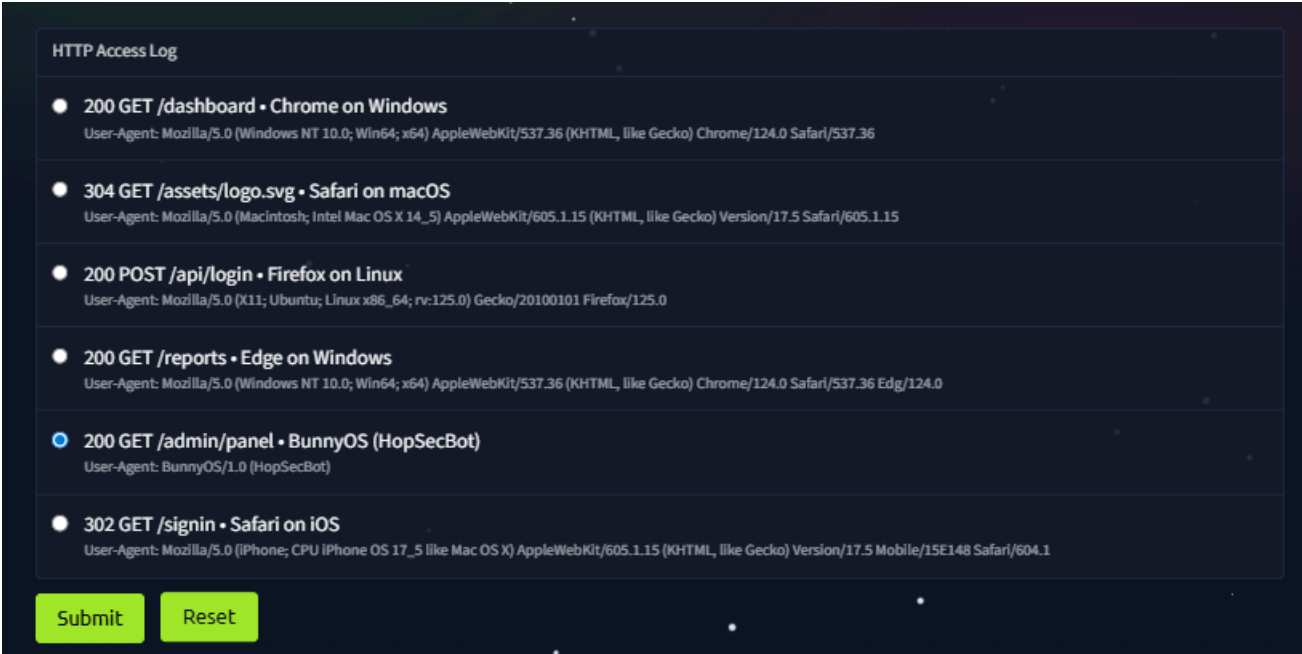
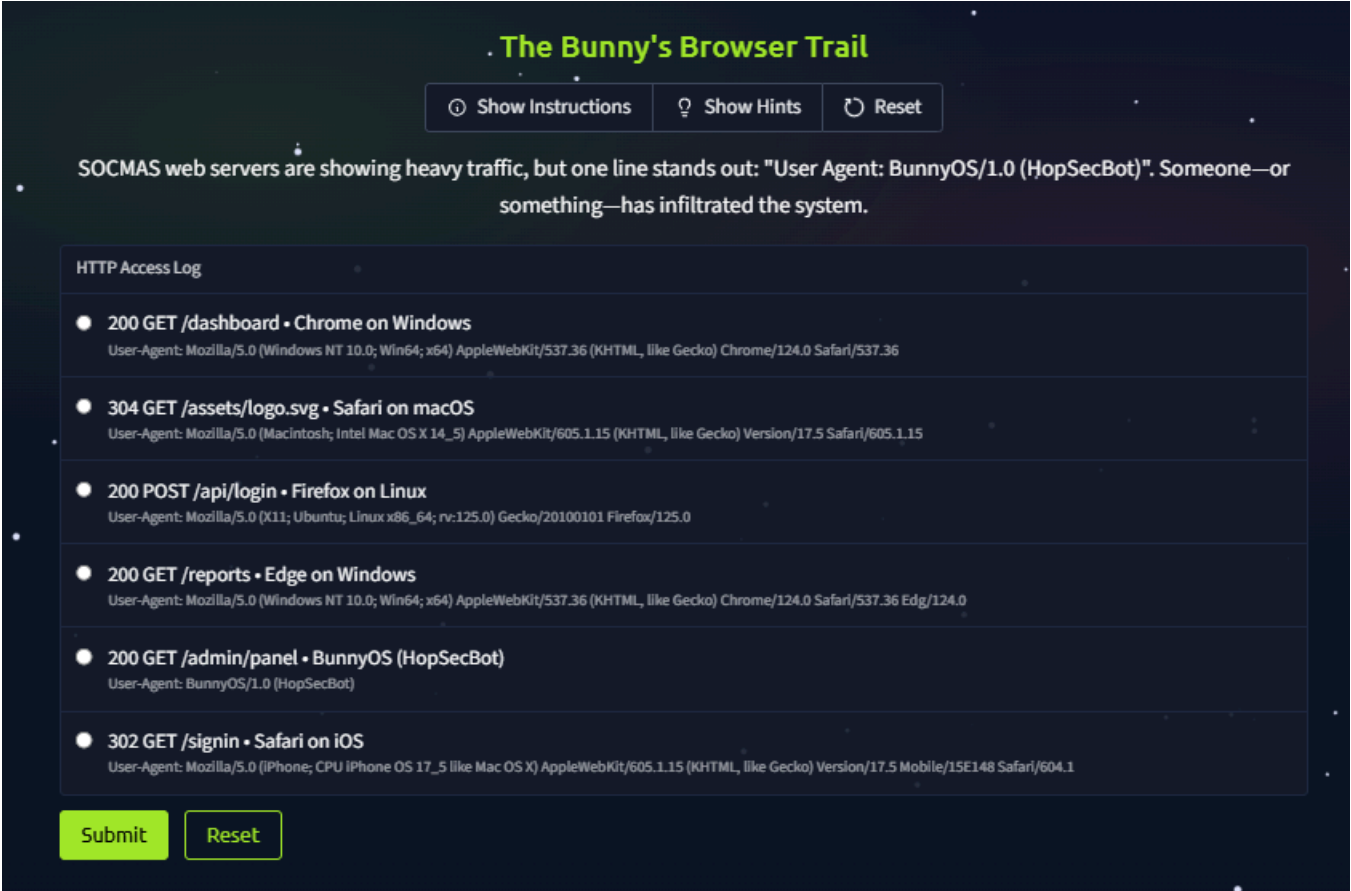
Find the unusual User Agent in the HTTP log.

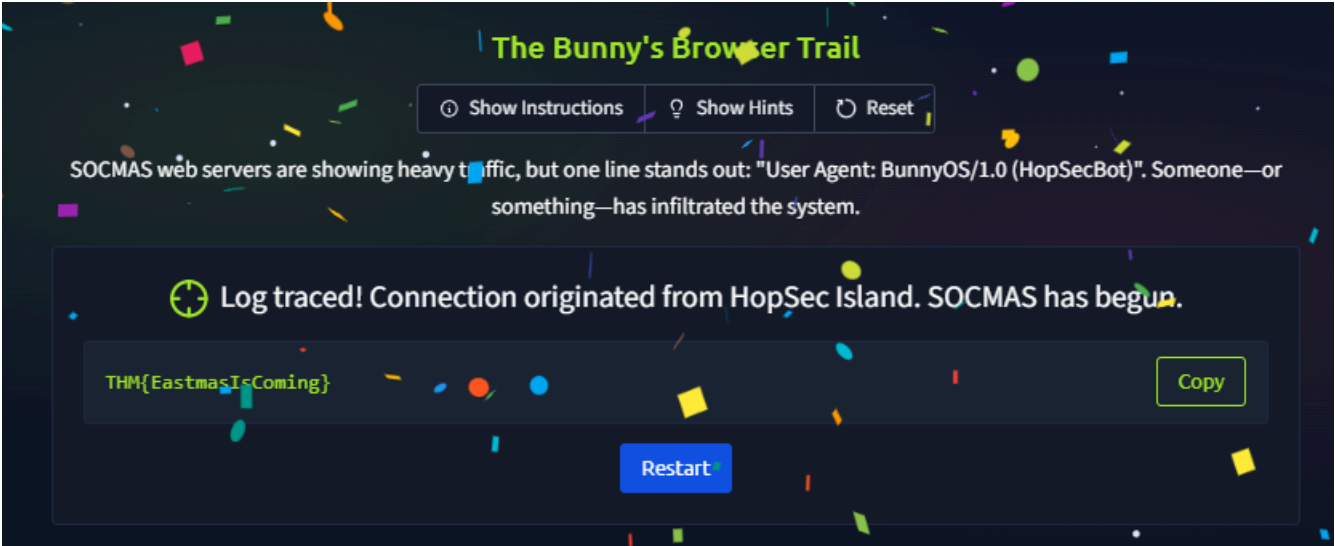
Steps:

- 1. Read the provided web log entries.
- 2. Compare them to common browsers (Chrome, Firefox, Edge).
- 3. Identify and select the suspicious entry.

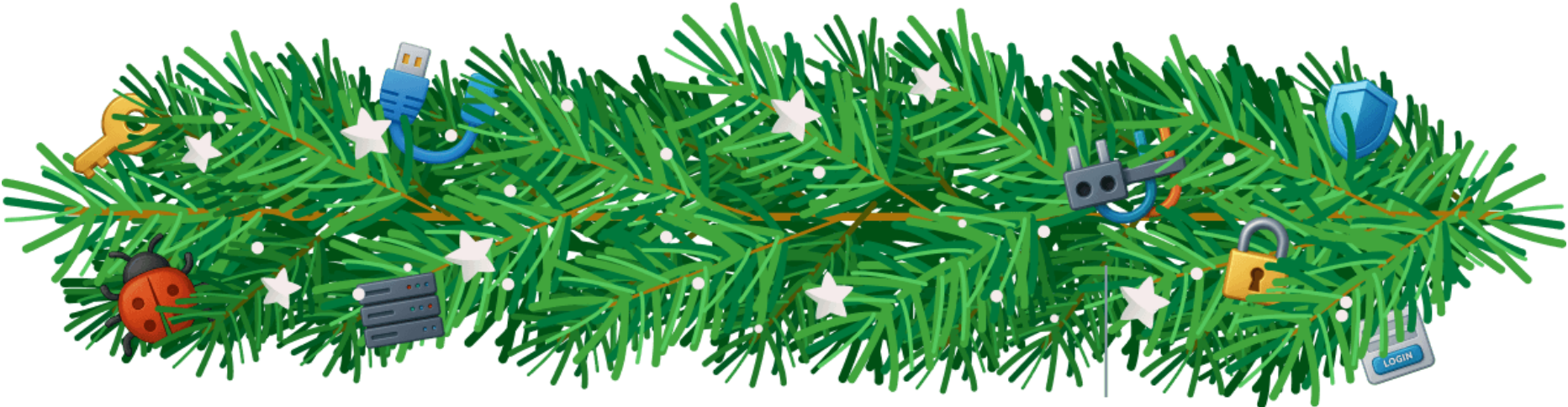
Answer the questions below

What's the flag?
THM{EastmasIsComing}





The Finish Line



Consider Yourself Warmed Up!

Well done for making your way through Advent of Cyber 2025's Prep Track! These mini challenges have been designed to familiarise you with some of the key tricks and tools you'll need at your disposal to **help save SOC-mas** in this year's event. If you're looking to start your cyber security journey, there's no better place to do it than with us, as we take you on a tour of topics from **Linux CLI** to **Prompt Injection**, getting you up to speed with the world of cyber and all, while earning chances to win some of our amazing prizes in our annual AoC giveaway!

Sounds like fun? It is! And you can wait for the fun to begin at this year's [Advent of Cyber landing page](#)!